

quantum systems are not available in India. They are available in the cloud for academic institutions and other partners, so that they can test and experiment with them.

Q. Is there a possibility or any initiative towards customising Linux for quantum computing? Or will a whole different set of software need to be developed for it?

A. I think this space will evolve, and Linux won't be required to run for quantum computing in the future. However, traditional systems will be required to work hand-in-hand with the quantum systems. Currently, traditional systems are going to continue to innovate the way they are at the moment.

Q. Has an organisation like IBM built a culture of motivating its teams to contribute, or is it just natural for developers to contribute?

A. I would say that it's a bit of both. We encourage people with a natural inclination towards contribution to collaborate and work with open source communities. Often, people want to work on open source projects, for which we give them that opportunity.

Over the years, we have built a culture of working in open source communities and a strategy of giving back to these communities, with respect to the technologies that we work upon.

We have a long history of doing this and continue to do so, as it is very important to us. As a part of this culture, we encourage people to participate and present their open source contributions. That is why it is important for our teams to go out to open source conferences and interact with people.

With 20 plus years of history, this culture is now kind of ingrained

in our working style and helps us to become good citizens in the open source community.

Q. While hiring, do you look at whether people have contributed to an open source project? And is this factor also considered for appraisals?

A. It's not necessary that one should have contributed to open source. But if such a contribution has been made, then it is definitely a plus point while hiring. And when we do look at people's open source contribution experience, then we focus on what are their contributions that will help them work with the community.

“Many contributions have been made by us, along with our collaborators, to IBM's AI Cloud Services (also known as Watson Machine Learning), which is based on open source frameworks.”

Q. Do you prefer to hire freshers or people with a certain level of experience for your team?

A. We usually hire across the spectrum, which includes fresh engineering graduates and experienced people.

Q. In your opinion, how evolved is India with respect to the open source and Linux ecosystem? Do we have the required talent or is that one of the challenges you face

as an engineering leader?

A. When we started out 20 years ago, there were very few contributors from India in the Linux kernel community. There used to be occasional contributions from some of the IITs.

But since then, the contributions have increased a lot. We see a considerable amount of exposure to Linux at the university level, especially in Tier 1 and Tier 2 engineering colleges. This familiarity with Linux has enabled people to do projects and take up credit courses based on Linux.

It is also worth mentioning that we see very good participation from people, especially from the technology cities of India. So, I think the trend is looking good. But there's always more that can be done with respect to training more and more people at the university level.

Overall, my observation is that in India, it has been a very good journey for Linux over the last 15 to 20 years.

Q. Is it correct to assume that now the discussion about Linux and open source, with a CIO or CTO, is much easier as compared to what used to be the case earlier?

A. Indeed, that's true. According to a survey on open source conducted by Red Hat this year, 89 per cent of the enterprises surveyed consider that open source plays an important role in their businesses. And 67 per cent have adopted open source for non-cost reasons.

For them, open source is bringing about lots of new innovations in a very short span of time due to its agility, security, robustness and reliability.

According to this survey, 59 per cent of the enterprises believe that the use of open source will increase in their organisations. So this is a good indication of the trend of using